Sonnets for an Old Century – Cutting 2

By Jose Rivera

WENDY JOHNSON (pg 121)

You stand here and make your statement.

That's it.

You want to fight with existence?

Go for it. You want to scream?

Knock yourself out.

Just remember:

your words go out to the universe, all your

words, to be, I don't know, recycled among

the living -- like rain, like part of --

some ecology of the spirit.

It's the last and only time you have

to give your side of the story, as far as I

know.

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INTRODUCTION

In a waiting room for the afterlife, we find a dreamscape filled with poignant and haunting monologues from recently deceased individuals. "Where do we go when we die?" And if you were to offer commentary regarding the life that you've lived, "What would you say?"

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ALENE DAWSON (pg 187)

My son had his first day of public school Monday.

We had him in a private school in Van Nuys

but it was a little too far away for us,

too expensive, and he'd come home all sad,

saying, "How come there are no

brown faces in my school, Mom?"

So we finally got him into a magnet in Echo Park

-- prestigious --

and there was an assembly Monday

and on the stage the principal got up

to talk to the new students and said,

"Okay kids, now don't you be bringing in

no guns to school in your backpacks!

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Hear that, children?
I want no guns, no knives,
no chains in your lockers
or in your backpacks
or on your person."
This is the principal!
This is a magnet school in the humanities!
And she says,
"Stay close to the school,
don't wander away from campus.
There have been drive-bys in this area
so don't leave the school grounds!"
I'm thinking, oh my God!
It's getting out of control.
We're at war.

Citizens killing citizens.

We don't need the government to bomb the city.
We do it to ourselves,
taking the knife to cut open the throats
of our own children,

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and then when we're out of hand,
when we're too good at that,
the police are brought in,
like an occupying army, you know,
jackboots all polished up,
hardware all glistening,
big robocop shoulders,
nightsticks ripping open the heads
of our little boys, it makes me crazy.
'Cause you know, it's all their fault!
The economy bad?
It's the black kids!
Air pollution?
The black kids did it!
The dollar down against the yen?
You know who to blame! God!
Made me want to take a rock
and hurl it at some politician,
some bozo running for Mayor,
any of those quicktongued hypocrites
assigned to protect the citizens,

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'cause, no, I didn't feel protected,
I felt ***exposed***, all opened up,
like some criminal was pointing
his Saturday Night Special at me
and every day I sensed those trigger fingers
out there and I was at the end
of their sights and they were just watching me,
waiting for the right split second
to send a little ounce of screaming steel
into the back of my brain!
God! God! It was not to be believed!
Being a woman in this city, sometimes,
oh my God,
I needed some help!
Especially when my boy went
out that door, you know?
And my imagination has created his killer,
some sweating overanxious rookie cop,
too afraid to piss straight,
slamming into my child at the wrong time,
in the wrong place, 'cause he's thinking,

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"Of course, boy's in a gang, it's natural,
they run in packs,
those boys up to no good, you bet.
But what'd you expect?
It's a genetic thing with the black kids,
they're innately less intelligent,
but don't talk to me,
it's already ***proven***,
there are ***statistics***,
it's testable,
they're naturally more comfortable
with a .45 in their hands
than a volume of Faulkner."
So why the hell not cut the school budget?
Why not send them off
to some genocidal death in the penitentiary?
It's a waste of good American tax money
trying to educate these
unteachable black kids!
Jesus Christ! It's time to build
another super-prison,

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you know, with a hundred nautilus machines
and hot tubs and libraries,
'cause, let's face it,
it's a whole lot nicer on the inside
than the corner of Florence and Normandie.
Going to jail is a good career move!
Oh God! If I wasn't a peaceful woman
I would've thrown rocks!

Trouble is, I don't think enough people
believe in the multiplicity of God.
Not enough people understand
God's great face has a nose
and eyes of a thousand shapes and sizes
and all of us, down to the last ugliest
and lowest person, we are all the living,
walking ***text*** of God.
Yes, the life story of God is
written into each one of us:
we are the pages in the book of God's mind.
And if we'd just take the time

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we'd be able to read God
in each other's faces,
read the funny lines as well as the lines
of wisdom and healing --
because the Word of God
isn't written in the Bible, no,
the Word of God is written in your mirror
and on your brother's black face
and in your son's blue eyes.

TRANSITION

And that little boy . . . Alene Dawson's son . . . an child immigrant from the poverty-stricken country of Nicaragua, found a better life in America. Yes, there was racism; yes, there were people who didn't want another immigrant in the U.S. . . . and he reached his teen years without his mother . . . but it was better . . . until it wasn't. This is his story in that great waiting room for the afterlife.

RICK COCA (Pg 129)

I was waiting outside the house
for almost an hour.
My **novia** *(girlfriend)* was working in this house.

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Anglo family.
Watching their children.
They were supposed to get back by eleven thirty.

It was past midnight.
We didn't think they'd want me in their house
so I waited in the car on the street in front.

I drove a small and dented Toyota.
The neighborhood was rich.
Big houses, not too much happening at
night. Dead and dark.
Sometimes you see coyotes looking for food.
Or an opossum crawling across the road.

Animals fascinate me.
Where I grew up you lived with animals.
You understood their habits.
You paid attention to what they needed
or they would die.
If they die, you die.

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I watched them being born!
I got used to blood and birth.

My mother taught me to kill chickens
with my hands.
You grab them around the neck and then
you spin them around.
They struggle and some of them can really
cut you bad if you're not careful.
When I was a child I loved to kill them like that.

Later I butchered pigs.
I pretended the pig was a condemned man,
a murderer, rapist, with no soul,
who never repented,
and spit at the priest giving him Last Rites
and mocked the sacraments
and the family of the victim,
boasted he raped little girls.
I held the knife tight.
Looked at the struggling, confused pig.

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Imagined the rapist or the unrepentant
murderer and I was chosen by the court to
execute this scum. I never smiled.
I never let the pig's --
I mean the prisoner's –
screams distract me.
I plunged the knife into its soft throat –
far as it could go --
and I cut and cut and the animal screamed
like a man and I imagined
the bleeding prisoner
finally understanding the meaning of his crimes,
repenting, fearing God,
believing in God's wisdom,
God's punishment, which I carried out.
I was the messenger of God,
the word of God, I said,
"Don't kill," "Don't rape," "Don't sin," . . .
I was the terrible messenger
and this knife was my message.
I took myself very seriously

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when I was ten years old.

To this day, animals fail to move me
with their dying, their breeding -- so what?
The coyotes hurrying through these bigshot
Anglo neighborhoods at night,
ignoring me in my Toyota as I wait for my
girlfriend -- so what?

I waited out there nearly an hour.
I was low in my seat,
thinking of my youth in Nicaragua
among animals.
It was dark and quiet.
I was about to fall asleep.
Far away I heard a car.
It wasn't going fast.
I thought "No."
I didn't move.
I could feel the sweat in my hands.
I thought *"No!'*

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I waited and decided to sit up.
The police lights shot on,
red and blue swirls colliding in my face,
my stomach turning into boiling water,
my mouth dry.
Two men got out.
One of them shined a flashlight in my face.
I waited.
The other cop stood behind the first
and he waited.
Man's eyes were cold.
Man's eyes stared right into me.
I turned my head
and wouldn't look in his eyes
as the other one told me to get out of the
car very, very slow,
hand on his gun,
the night very still,
coyotes long gone,
scared away by the action, instinctual.

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I stood there
and explained what my business was
on this street
and one of the cops looked at me
the way I used to look at the pigs
I was about to slaughter,
cold, convinced of my higher duty,
the spokesman of God,
the messenger,
the punisher,
the death-bringer.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jose Rivera
Book: Talk to Me: Monologue Plays
ISBN: 978-1400076154
Publisher: Vintage Books
Date (Month/Year): Dec 2004

AWARD HISTORY

2010 National Qualifier

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